your smile, my ghost, I fell to my knees

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/49330582.

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Flutterina (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Mentions of Shadow Weaver, Mentions of Horde Prime - Freeform, mentions of Shadow Weaver's A+ parenting, tgcf au, no tgcf knowledge needed though, homoerotic cpr, the dreaded coffin scene, Catra is so in love with Adora, Catra is also very insecure, Adora is just there for the ride, Bow is the best, someone check on Catra and make sure shes okay after the coffin scene, no beta we die like catra, I'm Bad At Tagging, sorry - Freeform

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Part 8 of oh i may weep forevermore (my love will never die)

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by orphan_account

Summary

She hears a clapping sound- as if Adora clapped her hands together -and Adora mumbling, “Please, forgive me…”

Then, Catra’s eyes snap open- because Adora’s kissing her. Adora’s eyes are closed, and she pulls back slightly- and if she just opened her eyes she would realize Catra is awake. Adora’s hand rests on the side of her face, thumb just underneath her mouth, and pulls her mouth slightly open. Adora descends again, their open lips making contact-

And that’s when Catra realizes… Adora isn’t kissing her, she's trying to give her CPR!

or, in which Catra is a Ghost, Adora is a god, and they're still searching for Shadow Weaver... and Adora doesn't understand how ghost's work.

Notes

heyyyy... in the words of Taylor Swift, it's been a long time coming! After a few months break, I am back... but not for long cause I don't think I'll be able to get the next fic out for this until at least September, cause I will be going on vacation next week! Anyways, I hope you enjoy this, it was a bit of a mess to write but yeah. Thank you everyone for sticking around!

title comes from This Love (Taylor's Version) by Taylor Swift!

See the end of the work for more notes

Contrary to the belief of many, Catra's powers were not limited in the slightest in Eternia. She could feel it, thrumming beneath her skin, hot and full of power. When she tried to use it, however- it was no use. She realized very quickly that it was her restraints, they were the thing barring her from releasing any of it.

So, she was left to rot in a cell. She didn't know what was going on with Eternia, after the shit show of her trial. No one has come to her, to let her know how things are going, or even tell her that she was free to go. She guesses she's just Eternia's prisoner, now.

How pathetic. The most powerful of the Ghost Kings, confined in Eternia- a *dungeon* - for the rest of Eternity.

No one was coming for her, she came to terms with that rather quickly. Adora will always choose work over her- she will always choose Eternia over her.

It happened when they were 18. Catra never expected more from her, really. And she's come to terms with that, thanks to Perfuma. So, it doesn't bother her as much as it should.

Adora choosing Eternia over her won't stop her from keeping her promise, her oath, intact.

Catra just supposes that this is what her life is destined to be- stuck in a cage. It’s funny how that's how her life started, how it ended. And, well, it’s how it’s going now, too.

Because of the fact that she was left relatively alone in that cell, save for the few guards who come and go to keep watch, it let her to… reflect. On a lot of things, but mainly one:

She could’ve ascended.

Fate, the universe, whatever it may have been- it tried to right itself, but by then it was too little, too late. She had already been set in her decision to be a Ghost King, so it made no difference then.

The more Catra thought about it though… if she had ascended when she was originally supposed to, on the day she died… she doesn’t think she would’ve accepted it then, either. She was so angry, so full of rage and hatred for Adora- but especially Eternia. She blamed Eternia for taking Adora away from her, and for that, she hated them.

She wouldn’t have stayed, if she had ascended when she was 19. In fact, she may have killed a few people up there before coming back down. So, in some twisted way, Angella’s sleight of hand did Eternia some good. Catra half appreciates it, now.

But she still feels robbed. Robbed of a life that she wasn't able to live, even if she knows she wouldn't have stayed. She feels bitter that someone who isn't even supposed to be a god, is a god. She took away a spot that someone else could've filled, someone more useful.

She feels incredibly bitter that she could've been saved so much of the pain that she endured. She reaches her hand, bound in chains, up to her neck to trace the scar there. Even as a ghost, the skin there is slightly raised. She knows if she were to shave the fur there, there would be an ugly mark.

That scar, it's the reason why she speaks slowly in her true form. The way in which she died- it damaged her vocal chords, it stops her from speaking at a normal pace.

Some wounds don't heal over, when you die. They're too great of wounds to just leave scars. She knows if she runs a hand over her body, her hands will dip in some place- they'll enter a wound that's healed, but still open. It's an odd thing, and most of the time she covers them, but now in Eternia, she can't. She's forced to feel the weight of how she died.

She was tortured. She knows that. It was cruel, it was public. She had been tortured all her life, though, so of course she knew she'd experience a violent death.

Wretched beginning, wretched end, she supposes.

She feels the weight of these things more on some days- and on others she completely forgets.

Being confined like this, left alone with her thoughts- it's a dangerous thing. Nothing good ever comes from Catra being left alone with nothing but her thoughts. The last time such a thing happened, it led to her death.

Maybe that's what this is. A third death.

She knows it won't be her last.

She stares at the metal bars confining her, restricting her powers and- they double. She think's she's hallucinating it at first but then- no, she realizes, she's dizzy.

Odd. The last time she felt dizzy was when…

It's nothing, she writes it off. It's just from withdrawals of… being away from Halfmoon. That's all it is.

She closes her eye and pretends she's fine- pretends she's somewhere else, and not locked in some dungeon in Eternia.

She isn’t sure how long she has her eye closed for when she hears the quick thuds- footsteps on the stairs leading into her cell. She doesn’t open them, just lets it happen. It’s probably just another guard changing watch. It’s fine.

The footsteps stop in front of her cell, then she hears rustling-

“I’m sorry it took me so long,” Adora murmurs. “I had a lot of things I had to attend to. I came as quickly as I could.”

“...Adora?” Catra questions, opening her eye. “You’re here?”

“Yeah, why wouldn’t I?” Adora answers, as if Catra was supposed to just *know* that she’d come back. “Did you think I wouldn’t… come?”

“No,” Catra sighs. “I guess not.”

Adora looks mildly hurt. She gets over it relatively quickly, “That doesn’t matter. What matters is getting you out- you don’t deserve this! You… I’ll get you out of here, okay?”

Catra smiles sadly at her, “It’s nothing I’m not already used to, your highness.”

Adora's silent, looking at her sadly then, "...What's that supposed to mean?"

It's quiet, broken almost. It's sad.

"Want to hear a story?" Catra asks instead, smirking slightly towards her. Adora nods, "Sure, yeah."

"Once, there lived a girl named-" Catra thinks for a moment. She can't say her own name, and even if she could.. She wouldn't. "Catarina. She was hated by many, for no good reason other than she was hideous. The woman who watched over her, why… she was so cruel, for reasons unknown. The woman hated Catarina the most, and whenever she could, she would throw her in the kingdom's dungeon.

"When she did that, she'd never feed her. Wouldn't provide her with any of the bare necessities, really. She'd keep her there for long periods of time, and say that she was preparing her for her duties as knight. She did it all under the guise of love- but it was hate. Never once was it out of love."

Adora is silent for a moment, the look on her face conflicted.

"That story isn't a very happy one," Adora mutters. Catra smiles sadly, "Life is often not happy, your highness. I'm sure you know this."

Adora nods her head- she's all too familiar with it. This, Catra knows.

"The girl in the story, Catarina," Adora speaks up again. "Was she you?"

Catra nods her head, "Bingo, blondie. You win the gold!"

Adora smiles, ever so slightly. "Was that your mortal name?" She asks- and if it was anyone else, Catra would skin them alive for asking such an intrusive question.

But it's Adora.

"No," Catra says. "Not really even close to it, actually. 'Catra' is closer to my mortal than Catarina."

"...May I ask what your mortal name was?" Adora questions, voice soft. She seems to understand the gravity of that question a mere second later- "I'm so sorry!"

Catra laughs quietly. "It's no trouble, your highness," She assures. "But I can't tell you.. The name was stolen from me, a long time ago."

“Stolen?”

“.. As a ghost fire, you can’t really… do much.” Catra begins to explain. “Any stronger ghost can just come around and do with you as you please. The higher you scale in the ranks, the less others can do- until you’re at my level, the top of the food chain.

“Anyways, I was a ghost fire and..” Catra sighs heavily. “Names are a huge thing for ghosts, you know.. It’s how we keep from being forgotten- names are our everything, really. They keep us here, like prayers and believers keep you from fading..”

“So without a name you’d-”

“Disappear.” Catra nods. “You have to make yourself memorable- make your name memorable enough that people don’t forget it. Shadow Weaver, she took my name from me as a Ghost Fire in an effort to make me disappear. I can’t answer to my mortal name anymore- can’t even say it, actually.”

“Have you.. tried?” Adora asks hesitantly. Catra smiles, and- she tries again.

C’yra. She tries to say, but her lips are sealed shut, her throat is closed. She tries to fight it, gods, she tries as hard as she can and-

She spits up blood, coughing.

"...That's what happens when I try," Catra murmurs, wiping her mouth on the back of her hand. "No use in trying, hm?"

"Why didn't you disappear, then?" Adora asks, baffled. "She took your name.."

"Someone still remembered me," Catra answers. "And my emotions were far too… strong to just be willed away by a name."

Adora was silent, watching- she knew Catra would continue.

"...A person close to me, she…" Catra trailed off, staring through Adora. "After I left Tong'lu, I had a hard time coming to terms with the fact that I couldn't answer to my mortal name anymore. It was the name that… one person loved me by. I mourned the name, and she- my friend, she said.. Nobody mourns like a ghost."

And it's true. Nobody mourns like a ghost. Ghosts, who mourn the lives they could have had, had fate been nicer to them.

"But she helped me learn that people don't fall in love with names," Catra says, a fond smile on her face. "They fall in love

with the person behind the name.”

Adora was… shockingly silent. Catra felt like she said the wrong thing, for a moment there and then-

“I never thought of it that way,” Adora confesses. “But your friend is definitely right. People don’t fall in love with the names, just the people who.. Have the name, so- so what if you can’t answer to your mortal name!? You can make people love you with your new name!”

Catra giggles. “Sounds a little manipulative, Adora,” Catra comments. “But yes, that is basically what she said to me.”

They share a comfortable silence- Adora looking at Catra with a small smile, and Catra looking down at her hands.

“...You shouldn’t focus on me, Adora,” Catra murmurs. “You should fix things here in Eternia, with your family and friends. They’re your home and- I’d hate it if you lost all of that because of me.”

Catra hates it there, gods, she really does- but she knows how much Adora’s friends and family mean to her. She can be focused on after Adora mends things with her family.

“Eternia isn’t my home!” Adora huffs. “Home isn’t a place, Catra, home is.. People.”

“And all of the people who make this a home are here,” Catra points out. “Mend things, Adora. You can focus on me after- but don’t burn bridges just because *I’m* uncomfortable.”

“But that’s what I’m trying to fix!” Adora sighs. “I’m trying to make sure you’re comfortable- by getting you out!”

“Adora,” Catra says, stern. “I spent 10 years inside of, essentially, a volcano. I will be fine, spending a few days within a cell.”

“But-”

“No buts,” Catra cuts off quickly. “Go work it out with them.”

They have a staring match- one that Catra wins. Adora sighs dramatically and relents, standing up and brushing off her robes.

“Fine!” Adora exclaims rather dramatically. “I’ll go and.. Talk to them, I guess. But I *will* find a way to get you out of here, okay?”

“Okay, Adora,” Catra laughs. “That’s fine with me.”

And then she was alone again.

—

Catra counts 3 days before she hears Adora's footsteps descending the stairs to her holding cell. By this point, Catra can tell just who is coming down there by the sound of their footsteps- Adora's were heavy, but they weren't loud or uninviting. They were just… distinctly Adora.

"I'm sorry that you're still down here," Adora says as soon as she sees Catra- sat in a meditative position in the middle of her cell. "I've been trying everything I can to get them to release you. Nothing is convincing them."

Catra cracks a smile. "That's alright," She assures. "I'm more worried about Melog than I am for myself."

Adora's face drains of all color. "Oh, gods, I didn't even think of Melog…"

Catra's smile turns sad, now. "This is the longest time we've ever been separated…" She murmurs. "And they tend to get very anxious so… I'm just worried as to how they're holding up, is all."

"...Gods, I can go and try to find them-" Adora quickly amends, making to walk out. "I don't want anything to happen to them!"

"..It's no worries, your highness…" Catra responds. "That wretched thing can do with a few days without me. It'll be okay."

Adora looks at- stares at her, really -before sighing and sitting down. The only thing separating them were metal bars, hot to the touch for ghosts but to gods, it felt like regular metal.

"I managed to make.. amends with some of them." Adora tells Catra, her voice quiet. "Mainly Bow and Adam. They really didn't do much, it was… everyone else."

"Don't lump in Perfuma," Catra tsks. "Perfuma tries her best."

"Oh, I meant to ask you actually," Adora sits up straight, looking Catra right in her eye with a look of determination. "How do you and her highness Perfuma know each other?"

A slow, lazy smile finds its way to Catra's face. It felt like just yesterday, when she wandered out of Tong'lu and found her way right to Plumeria.

"Gods, it was such a long time ago," Catra recalls, a far away, almost wistful look in her eye as she remembers. "I met her when I was 18, a few months before I died. I was… not the easiest to be around and she took pity on the manic Horde soldier- honestly,

it’s a miracle that she didn’t perform a lobotomy on me right there and then, when I showed up.

“Regardless, at the end of my visit, she told me I was always welcome back in Plumeria,” Catra sighs, shaking her head. “I wouldn’t take that offer up until 90 years after, just after I escaped Tong’lu. I had nowhere else to go- no one I knew, so I went to her. I stayed with her for decades, just trying to figure out who I was, what my name was, the king of Ghost King I wanted to be and… well, somewhere along the way, she became family to me.”

Adora has a soft smile on her face- one of adoration. “Was she the one who told you that people don’t love names?”

“Ah, you know me too well,” Catra snorts. “She is. She’s the reason I’m this put together, today- if it wasn’t for her, I’d be erratic and all over the place. Not the kind of person you’d want to meet, for sure.”

Adora laughs, finding humor in what she said- and Catra watches as Adora’s face falls, a frown settling on her face.

“..Your highness, what’s wrong?” Catra mutters, not wanting to speak too loudly and risk startling Adora, who looked deep in thought.

“..Sorry,” Adora responds, voice just above a whisper. “I was- Do you remember when we met? And I- I asked you what you were like as a mortal and you said you weren’t a very good person… I just- I can’t understand how you can be…”

She trails off, huffing. Catra feels her lips quirk up- she could see the frustration on her face, probably not knowing how to say what she was thinking.

“I don’t believe you,” Adora settles on. “That you were a bad person as a mortal. You’re a good person, Catra. You may be a Ghost King but- that doesn’t make you a bad person, not by any means.”

“Oh, Adora,” Catra sighs, looking down at her hands. “...If only you knew who I was, in my mortal life.”

“What is that supposed to mean?” Adora asks.

“You’ll know, one day.” Catra says. “I'm just not sure when.”

Adora is silent for a moment, contemplating Catra’s words when–

“Catra,” Adora mumbles. Catra responds with a hum, extending her claws and picking out dirt stuck behind them. “Can I ask you a question?”

Adora sounds odd. “Of course you can, your highness.”

And Adora doesn’t say anything right away- and Catra can see it, when she looks at Adora. Can see the look on her face, the look that says she's weighing her options.

Adora doesn’t know what she’s going to ask, Catra can see it clearly. Or, Adora doesn’t know if what she’s going to ask is a good idea- and that, alone, is enough to put Catra on edge.

Adora never thinks like that, never thinks that anything she says can be harmful to someone- and that was a fact that Catra resented, for a long time… and-

“...Have we met before?” Adora asks, her eyes shining with a hope Catra hasn’t seen in her in centuries. “As mortals, I mean.”

The pained look that crosses Catra’s face is not well concealed. Catra has always had a good poker face but this- this is a wound that’s never healed. It’ll never heal cause-

No one mourns like a ghost.

Like all things in this wretched world, the curse surrounding Catra has changed- evolved. She used to only be able to not answer to

her mortal name, but now- she can't even answer whatever questions that Adora may have about their intertwining mortal lives. She can't open her mouth, can't even try to make a sound with her voice. She can feel her vocal chords ripping, trying to answer Adora- trying to tell her that *yes, we have!*

Adora just watches her, confused at the pained and distraught look on the woman's face. A look that Adora has never seen on her, before.

"Catra?" Adora questions, looking concerned. "Are you okay? You look kind of, well… pale."

That breaks the spell- she can feel her throat open up and allow her to speak again. "...Yeah," Catra coughs rather violently. "I'm alright… what makes you think that, your highness?"

Catra may not be able to answer Adora's questions- but she can certainly ask Adora things, and see if Adora can come to her own conclusions.

"Well, I mean," Adora sighs, looking off towards the ground with a faraway look. "I don't know, just a feeling, I guess. You- you know a lot about me, like the thing with Frosta and… you just seem like you *really* know me, sort of intimately, I guess? And- the things you describe from your mortal life seem oddly familiar to things I'd hear about happening…"

Catra stays silent, waiting for Adora to continue.

"Like- you knew I was a Crown Princess!" Adora blurts out. "At- in my shrine, in Thaymor, you said… Your Highness the Crown Princess… and, I don't know how you would have known that, unless you were.. In the Fright Zone at the same time as me? There are no historical records, as far as I'm aware of, that say I'm a Crown Princess of any sort.. The only people who even know about that are the gods here in Eternia."

Catra smiles, slow and lazy. Adora was always smart- just not in the obvious ways. Adora could deduce things, could gather evidence and create conclusions from the evidence she has. And- well, Adora has a lot of evidence.

"Can I ask you another question?" Adora asks, more conviction and confidence to her, now.

"Of course you can," Catra says rather lazily, trying to come off as unphased as possible but- in truth, she was scared. Adora was right there, staring at the answer as to who Catra was in the eye and.. If Adora figured it out, everything could change. "You can ask me whatever you like, your highness."

"Are the rumors true," Adora inhales deeply and then exhales aggressively. "That in your mortal life, you were the royal knight to the heir of the Fright Kingdom?"

She can’t answer it. It falls under the ambiguous curse- and since this question directly implicated Catra to be C’yra… she can’t answer.

It’s agonizing, trying to answer Adora just to feel the blood slowly rising up in her throat.

Still, she tries everything she can to answer- and only stops when the blood collects too much in the back of her throat, causing her to cough out blood. It spatters on the floor, on the bars- and her throat feels like it’s been scratched out by a creature with jagged, deep claws.

She sees the look of frustration on Adora’s face. “The blood that- it only comes up when you try to say your mortal name, I thought?”

“It applies to… things regarding my mortal life now, too.” Catra explains, trying to wipe away the blood with the back of her hand. She coughs again, feeling more blood rise and catch itself between cracks in her throat. If her powers weren’t restricted, or if Melog were here, she’d be able to heal herself quickly. “Things that are muddled with certain people- stolen from me, so that no one can remember who I was in my mortal life.”

“That’s quite cruel,” Adora mutters. “It doesn’t shock me that Shadow Weaver did such a thing to you.”

“Her methods were always quite barbaric,” Catra agrees. “...But, I do still know people from my mortal life.. who know who I am. I’m sure that…”

They’d tell Adora, if Adora asked. In fact, Catra is sure that those two imbecile gods that Adora calls friends would be able to figure out who Catra was, given they actually have a conversation with her.

It’d take Glimmer more time to figure it out- but she knows Bow would figure it out quickly. He’s always been the smarter one of the bunch, even as mortals- and they never saw him that way. Always see him as jovial and playful, not half as smart as he is. Catra always knew, though- because she thinks they’re similar in that sense.

She refuses to acknowledge her similarities with Glimmer.

Catra doesn’t finish her sentence, just trails off and leaves it like that. She sees that Adora understands.

And it’s silent between them for a few moments. Just watching each other, and it feels… weird. It’s a comfortable silence, but there’s tension- something underlying, that isn’t being said.

Catra isn’t sure how much longer she can deal with this- with Adora not knowing. But she knows- gods, she knows if Adora knew who she was, Adora would want nothing to do with her.

“Do you have any regrets?” Adora asks suddenly, watching her hands.

“Sure,” Catra responds easily. “Everyone has regrets, don’t they?”

Adora seems to ponder her words then, “I have too many regrets, I think,” Adora murmurs, her voice… sad. “Hindsight really is twenty-twenty, isn’t it?”

“That’s just how life is, your highness,” Catra laments. “I learned a lot of things from my time in Tong’lu, but… I guess one of the biggest lessons I learned is that you have to embrace your regrets and use them to maneuver your future. You can’t change the past, but you can mold your future.”

“And what of fate?” Adora asks, her tone genuinely curious. “Or the heavens? Everything is set in stone from the moment you’re born- at least, that's what I've always thought.”

“...Your fate is yours to choose,” Catra says, gesturing slightly with her hands. “No paths are bound.”

“What makes you say that?” Adora presses, wanting to hear Catra’s reasoning.

“If my fate was decided by the heavens, and I let it stay as it was…” Catra begins, her words coming out slowly, each word particular and articulate. “...I would not be in the current position I am in. I would not be a calamity.”

Adora is silent- but Catra can see the confusion on her face. So, she continues,

“If I let my fate be, I would be gone- in my next life,” Catra explains. “...my inability to let things go, and my anger towards what I was given has put me in this position. No, not fate- I paved my own way, I decided my fate, not the heavens.”

—

She is alone for another 3 days.

This time, the footsteps that walk down those steps aren’t Adora’s. Catra’s actually quite curious as to who this could be, as none of the gods besides Adora have visited her. She guesses that none of them are permitted to, and Adora just went behind their backs.

She sniffs the air and- it smells like magic, sparkle magic.

Glimmer.

By the time she comes into view, Catra already has a sly smile on her face. Lazy, uncaring, threatening even.

Glimmer, shockingly enough, doesn't say anything to her. She just stares at her, this constipated look on her face.

"What?" Catra bites out. "Come to watch me suffer?"

Glimmer says nothing, not rising to the bait. Catra is… impressed.

"I'm sure it feels good," She continues, uncaring as ever. "To know you stole the godhood of a disgrace, of a monster. I'm sure you take pride in it, even.. Do you go around Eternia now, gloating about it?"

Still, nothing.

"Or do you feel remorse?" Catra ponders, crawling towards the bars. She can't touch them- she'll get burned, if she does, but she can come close enough to them to look up at Glimmer. "I doubt you do. You've made your hatred for me very clear, your highness… and you're a prideful creature."

She knows she's riling her up- she can tell by the look on her face, and she can hear it in her quicker intakes of breath.

Catra rolls her eye and allows herself to collapse on the floor, sighing. She doesn't have the energy to antagonize the god any longer. "Whatever," She murmurs. "Just leave. I don't need you here, looking down upon me. You're no better than me and- the fact that you think you are, is infuriating."

Glimmer just stands there, staring. She looks like she has something to say and yet- she says nothing. Just stares.

And then she leaves.

. . .

She returns again the next day, and she stays for a longer time. Watching, waiting.

Catra doesn't say anything to her this time. She isn't sure what, or why, Glimmer is doing this.

Glimmer leaves after 5 minutes, this time.

. . .

Glimmer is watching her, again- but this time, it looks like she's contemplating something. Considering saying something.

Catra is sick of it, sick of her visits where all she does is stare at her, like an animal locked in a cage.

It reminds her too much of Shadow Weaver.

“Spit it out,” She murmurs. “Yell at me, scream, curse me for the next 5 lifetimes for all I care, just… say it.”

“...I do feel sorry,” Glimmer says, looking down at Catra with a look that can only be described as remorseful. “I didn’t know that she… did that. I feel like I robbed you, and it’s a stupid feeling to have, cause you have more now than you would’ve had in my position but- it was still yours.

“But I don’t feel bad, either. You’re not a good person.” Glimmer states it with such conviction that Catra believes her. Catra has always known that- and she never needed Glimmer to tell her that. “Not in the slightest. You were loyal to the Fright Kingdom till your dying breath, and that itself is an unforgivable crime. That’s why I’m a better person than you- a better fit for a god. So, while I feel sorry for you- I don’t feel bad.”

Catra can’t help the laugh that escapes her, then. She doesn’t have the energy to sit up- she’s beginning to think her cell is also draining her of her energy. She’s getting increasingly more light headed, the longer she stays- and her bouts of nausea are always worse than the last.

“You’re a fucking hypocrite,” Catra spits out, looking up at Glimmer with as much hate as she can muster. “What makes Adora redeemable, but me a monster? She was a horde soldier- shit, she was the heir. What makes Adora, the Crown Princess of the Horde, more redeemable than me, who died a force captain?”

“Adora knew that the horde was wrong,” Glimmer seethes, fists clenching at her sides. “She pledged to work with the alliance, she faced her Knight- she looked her in the eye, and she told her she wasn’t coming back. She continuously fought against her, after being allied with her for almost 18 years… and you died while still under the Horde’s control. That’s the difference.”

And Catra stares at her, snarling- and she knows exactly what she wants to say to her. She wants to tell her *I knew the horde was wrong!* She wants to yell that she *chose* to stay because it hurt too much to admit that Adora was right for leaving.

But she doesn’t want to share that part of her. Not with Glimmer. Maybe not even with Adora.

So instead, she rolls over, away from Glimmer, and sighs out, “Not everything is as black and white as you make it out to be, sparkles.”

She doesn’t come back down after that.

—

She has a new visitor after a day to herself.

“Crimson Knight,” He says, smiling down at her. She narrows her eye at the man, confused as to why he was there- and why he was smiling at her. But, well, she reasons that Bow was always

the nicer one of the group. "I… would say you look like you're doing well, but…"

Catra stares at him, thoroughly unamused.

"Ha… okay, anyways," He laughs nervously and looks away. "I came down here because-"

"Just spit it out already, Arrow boy."

He deflates with a sigh.

"Well, I've been thinking lately and I wanted to ask you something," He confesses, looking back at her, then pulls out a scroll of some kind from his sleeve. "Or, well, I suppose the wording would be that I'd like to *confirm* something with you."

She raises an eyebrow and sits up slightly, intrigued. "Go on…"

He nods, he gulps, and looks down at the scroll. "Back in my day, before Eternia and before Adora ascended for a second time, there was a Knight within the Horde," He reads off the scroll. "She had tan skin, curly, wild hair, a short temper, cat-like features and an eye that was always covered by a bandage. Adora said her name was C'yra, and that she used to be her… Imperial knight."

Her brows slowly knit together. What is he doing?

"Adora and her were best friends," He glances up at her. "Adora would say that C'yra knew everything there is to know about her. She said C'yra turned bitter and angry when she never returned to the horde."

"What is the point of this, Bow?" She asks, laying back down to stare at the ceiling of her cell. She was so… tired.

"I'm going to ask you a series of questions," He tells her instead. "I ask that you please answer truthfully."

She's still for a moment, but nods after thinking it over. He mutters a quiet thanks and glances at the scroll.

"You were a Knight in your mortal life?" He asks. Catra nods. He clears his throat. "Okay, thank you. You served a Princess, correct?"

Catra finds that, curiously enough, she can actually verbally answer the question. "Yes." She confirms, glancing at Bow from the corner of her eye. She supposes that his question was vague enough to not trigger the curse…

"A Crown Princess, one would say?"

“Yes?”

“Catra sounds a lot like C’yra..” He murmurs, mostly to himself. “Catra, one last question. Were you alive when I was a mortal?”

Catra sits up abruptly, staring at him in disbelief. He watched her, as well, a lazy smile on his face as he rolled up the scroll and stuffed it into his sleeve again. She tries to open her mouth to speak, but it’s glued tightly shut. When she tries to make a sound with her mouth closed, all that comes out is a strangled gurgle. She spits out blood- and Bow laughs.

“So, it is like that.” He exclaims, a curious gleam in his eyes. “It’s good to see you again, Red Knight. It’s also good to see that you no longer hold your animosity towards Her Highness any longer!”

Catra looks away, gulping- she can’t believe this. Can’t believe that Bow only came down here for *that.*

“Will you speak to me?” He asks- and he obviously is aware of this curse, if his previous reaction said anything. He must’ve known asking an unrelated question would break it, would allow her to talk.

“...You were always the smart one,” She coughs, still not daring to look at him. “This comes as no shock to me.”

“Well, it also doesn’t help that you used to call me Arrow boy back then, too,” He laughs heartily. “Not so creative, eh?”

“You have no right to speak to me in such a way..” She grumbles, but it’s mostly in good humor. She thinks Bow knows that. He claps his hands together, and she can hear his slow footsteps inch closer to the stairs.

“Well, then, with this settled,” He declares, backing out. “I shall leave you be and- Crimson Knight, I promise I won’t say anything to Adora. I know that you probably view this as your second chance.”

“Third, actually.” Catra corrects him quietly.

He doesn’t hear her.

—

She’s been in Eternia’s dungeon for around 2 weeks when Adora comes barreling down, angry as ever, murmuring to herself.

She stops in front of the cell, looking down at a very sickly looking Catra.

“I’m getting you out of here,” Adora says, her tone stern. “And I’m getting you help. You aren’t going to fight me on it, either. I can’t stand to look at you like this.”

“..Your Highness,” She rasps out, barely able to keep her eye open. “It’s okay…”

Adora huffs and- Catra watches in slight amazement as Adora transforms into the mighty goddess of myth- She-ra.

She’s been with Adora for.. What, 3 months now? And not once had she ever seen the girl transform into the fabled warrior She-ra. Catra has heard the stories, the poems, the myths about She-ra and her strength- of her achievements but…

Catra never expected them to be true. She-ra truly looks… well, powerful and as beautiful as the legends say.

She-ra’s eyes glow bright blue, and Catra watches in slow motion as she grabs the bars of the cell and begins bending them into an arch. Catra would never admit it out loud but- she watches the way her arms strain against it, putting all of her strength into bending that metal for *her.*

Catra feels light headed- but she has a feeling it's not from this mysterious illness that she’s caught.

Catra closes her eye tight, trying to block out the sight of She-ra's arms straining and flexing because really, if she kept watching she was going to have indecent thoughts but instead-

Closing her eye caused her ears to make up for the lost sense, and she hears it now. Her heavy breathing, the grunting.

Catra just could *not* win, could she?

She snaps her eye open, instead just choosing to hone in on her face- and pointedly ignores the muscles. And the breathing. She's fine, this is fine. Totally fine. She is not panicking at all, not in the slightest.

Eventually, She-ra deems the bars far enough apart and steps into the cell, then walks over to Catra. She looms over her, like this. Catra estimates her to be at least 7 feet tall…

"What are you-" Catra yelps, getting cut off by Adora picking her up and carrying her bridal style.

"We're leaving," Adora mutters and- Catra can feel the rumbling in Adora's chest from speaking. She thinks she's about to faint. "I'm getting you out of here."

And, well- That's exactly what she does.

Adora, carrying Catra- Crimson Night Striking Mercilessly, the Crimson Knight -out of Eternia's dungeon, and down the main street of Eternia.

People watch them- because of course they do. There's She-ra, revered warrior and Goddess of War, the Princess of Power… carrying a demon. Cradling a demon would actually be a better term.

Catra, if she was in the right mind, would feel smug. But- she isn't, because even outside of the cell she feels… light headed, but she feels a strong *need.*

And she knows what time it is. She knows what this is but- she doesn't want to believe it, not until she talks to DT…

They don't even make it to the gates at the end of Eternia before Catra passes out.

—

She wakes up in the dilapidated She-ra shrine in Thaymor. Adora is at her side, gripping her hand tightly and-

She finds that in her sleep, she reverted into a form she hasn't used in centuries- her child form. Her hair was as curly as ever, slightly matted, and her left eye was covered by her usual

eyepatch but other than that she looked- she looked like her mortal self did as a child.

She sees Melog at her side, purring violently while also being in a smaller form, as well.

"...You really worried me, you know," Adora says, sighing with relief. "You completely just- passed out! I thought you were dead!"

"Adora," Catra says, completely deadpan. "I'm already dead."

"Don't remind me!" She cries, seemingly genuinely distressed. "And- and then you turned into this form and I was so confused and I was nervous, so I called Perfuma and she said she knew how to handle it and- I'm just glad you're awake…"

She sees it, now- one hand gripping Catra's, and the other hand gripping the ring around Adora's neck. She watches as Adora's grip on the ring loosens, and her finger strokes the ring-

She feels a shiver go down her neck, as if someone ran their finger from the base of her hair to where her spine meets her shoulders.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks, her voice gentle and caring, now. Her grip on Catra's hand also loosens but.. She's grateful for it,

nonetheless.

Catra hesitates. "...Yeah, I'm okay," She answers, her voice distinctly child-like. "I think the cell was just draining me of my magic and spiritual powers, so I felt sick…"

That's not what it is. She knows what it is but… she needs to see Double Trouble, quick.

Adora seems to accept her explanation. "Alright, good," Adora smiles. "We should… discuss some stuff. About Shadow Weaver and-"

Being in that cell for so long, it gave Catra the time to think. To mull over everything that's happened. As much as it drained her, she was sort of glad for the change of pace to process everything…

"...I forgive Glimmer," Catra murmurs, slowly shifting out of her child form and into a more comfortable skin. She didn't have enough power to go into her true form- but it was that of a teenager. Human, freckles spattered across her skin, blue eye shining, curly but slightly more tamed hair. "If that's what you want to talk about. It wasn't her choice, it wasn't her decision- it was her mothers and…"

Catra sighs, shrugs. "Sure, the decision her mother made pretty much ruined my life and took my future away from me, and I am

angry- but it wasn't Glimmer's fault. Besides, I can't change the past…"

Adora is silent for a moment, staring at something next to Catra- rather than looking at Catra. "...Well, that was definitely one thing I wanted to speak about," Adora sighs, shoulders relaxing with the exiting of her breath.

"What of Shadow Weaver?" Catra asks, her voice soft from the lack of energy. She doesn't have it in her to conceal the way she looks at Adora- full of adoration, of reverence.

"We need a plan," Adora says, gripping Catra's hand tighter. "Do you remember what we were talking about before you were… arrested?"

Catra nods, closing her eye to try and block out the harsh light. "...Yeah," She mumbles. "She's hiding out in a territory of the Ghost Realm that's unexplored or- even undiscovered. Which just means that we have to find it…"

Adora's silent, seemingly thinking. The quiet of the shrine brings Catra into her own head- somewhere she hasn't been in gods only know how long.

Catra always found that when she was weaker in power, she could hear him. He's silent, repressed even, when she has the power to

hold him down but now- now she can hear him in her head, loud and clear.

A result of devouring an ancient being, she supposes.

"You know, little sister," He says, his voice rattling off the walls of her skull. *"Wherever she is- he won't be far behind."*

"What do you mean?" Catra responds, brows furrowing. She hears his soft laugh, not nearly as mad as it was back in Tong'lu.

He's found… peace, over their centuries together. Or, at least, what she thinks is peace.

"She follows him blindly," Shanyuan explains. *"Gods only know why, but if you find her… you'll find brother."*

"...So you're saying I could kill two birds with one stone?" She questions, slowly catching onto what he's saying. She can see the pleased smile that crosses his face, but feels the way he shakes his head.

"Well, yes," He agrees. *"But not in this state. It's opening, little sister- you're aware of that, I'm sure. You must be in the best condition possible, to fight them…"*

So, obviously not like this. Not when she feels so weak that she can't even enter into her true form.

But she knows what comes next- that she will feel so powerful that she physically has to stay out of her physical form, unless she wants to succumb to her…. urges.

"Your god is speaking to you," Shanyuan points out. *"I'll check in again later, little sister."*

It's silent in her head again before- *"...You're doing well."*

Catra tunes back into Adora. "When you're ready to go, we should go and find them."

"Not alone," Catra murmurs. "Who knows where we'll be going- someone should come with us."

"But-"

"No buts, Adora," Catra firmly states. "Look at the condition I'm in. Do you think I'm anywhere near fit to go?"

Adora is silent. Catra opens her eye, staring right at Adora. "I'm stuck like this, you know. For a while at least. We need someone

else with us- it doesn't have to be a god, it can.. It can be Double Trouble, or- I don't know.. just someone."

"Catra…" Adora trails off, this constipated look on her face- one that Catra knows to mean that Adora *doesn't* agree with what she's saying. Her tone reflects that. "Do you *know* how powerful I am? Gods- I'm the Princess of Power! Who cares if you're stuck like that!? I have enough strength and power to protect the both of us, wherever it is that we go."

"It's not a good idea," Catra doubles down. "You don't know what could happen to you- what could happen to *me.* We need someone with us."

"No we don't, Catra!" Adora cries, hand tightening in hers. "We don't need anyone else- just us! We can go ourselves, I can protect you-"

"Adora, no!" Catra cuts her off quickly. "You don't understand how dangerous the ghost realm can be, especially *uncharted territory.* Territory that could be occupied by an honorary ghost king!"

"It doesn't matter!" Adora was getting increasingly more desperate- and Catra didn't understand. Why was she so adamant on it just being them? Did she not want to ask for help? She was always prone to doing that… "I've faced many things, in the past- with no information or knowledge. We'll be fine, with Horde Prime dead it can't be… that dangerous!"

This was a fight oddly reminiscent of when they were mortals. This was a fight they'd have, many times actually.

(*"You can't go alone, Adora," C'yra crosses her arms, eyeing the Princess carefully. "Shadow Weaver would never allow it."*

"And she'd never let you *come either," Adora points out. "So, I'm going."*

"No, you aren't," C'yra presses, slowly walking towards her. "You're not going anywhere without me. It's my duty to protect you, always and forever. So I'm coming with you."

"I don't need *you to protect me!" Adora exclaims, breathing heavy. "Gods- I don't need you to protect me at all, you aren't coming with me!"*

"Well, too fucking bad," C'yra bites out. "You plan on infiltrating Bright Moon yourself? Good luck trying. It's a death mission, no matter how powerful you believe yourself to be."

"So then why do you want to come with me?" Adora asks. "If it's a death mission- why waste your life by coming with me?"

"Because!" C'yra yells, face to face with Adora now, shoving a finger into her chest. "If you die, it's on me! I'm the one Shadow

Weaver will come after if she hears news of you dying and me not trying to stop you- or, you know, dying with you!"

C'yra's breathing hard now, too. Her chest heaving up and down, staring Adora right in the eye as she yells in her face. "If you die, and I wasn't there to stop you- or die with you, because we all *know how much she hates me -I will die a long, terrible, torturous and miserable death at* her *hands. Because of* you *, and your reckless, half-assed decisions."*

The look on Adora's face is one she won't ever forget. Not even 4 centuries later.

And later, she'll look back on this fight and realize that- in the end, she still died a long, tortuous death at the hands of Shadow Weaver, prompted by Adora.

It's almost ironic, that she fought so hard for Adora not to go out on her own unless she wanted C'yra dead and… she still died, either way.)

"...You're a fool," Catra mumbles, not having the energy to fight Adora on this. "A gigantic fool. We won't leave the ghost realm alive if we go, just us two."

"What are you suggesting?" Adora questions. "That you just go, by yourself? So that you can die?"

“I’m already dead,” Catra points out. “And it doesn’t matter how many times I die, I’ll always come back.”

“How do you know that?”

“First, my ashes are safe,” Catra explains. “Second… I have a will to live on in this world, as a ghost.”

Adora is silent, and Catra knows she’s waiting for an explanation- an elaboration.

Catra, however reluctantly, provides her with one. “...I’ll keep coming back no matter what, because I still have someone precious in this world. One who I swore to protect centuries ago and I- I will *never* stop. That’s what keeps me in this world, your highness.”

“Someone… precious?” Adora asks, her voice small and– Catra thinks she imagines the hurt in Adora’s voice.

Catra smiles and nods. “Precious, indeed.” She says. “She’s the… kindest, most noble… bravest, person I know. She’s gracious, even… but she’s also a fool, but it’s endearing sometimes.”

Adora is quiet and- Catra just can’t stop, now that she’s started.

"I've been by her side for as long as I can remember," She reminisces. "She took me in, protected me and, in return, I protected her. I will continue to protect her, for saving my life."

"Catra," Adora mumbles- and she sounds so sad. Unbelievably sad. Catra distantly registers Adora's grip on her hand relaxing, slowly slipping out. "Can I ask you something?"

"Anything."

"...You told me once that when you become a Ghost, your ghost life is separate from your mortal life.." Adora begins, slowly articulating her words. "And then you told me it was true that you used to be a Knight as a mortal. Why do you… continue to identify with that part of your life?"

Catra sighs. She didn't think she'd ever have to answer that question- never thought anyone would really *ask.* No one has ever had a high enough position to ask her such a question and not worry about dying by her hands.

And yet, here Adora is. Asking.

"It's what I am, in my core," Catra mumbles. "A Knight, serving someone else- someone higher than me. I am always, and will

always be a Knight. I won't ever escape that, and I never wish to escape my duty to my beloved."

(*"I'll bring you up as my Middle Court Official- and then we can be together! You can be my Knight Forever!" She had said. And she had been more than happy to be just that- her knight.)*

"...part of me hopes that when we meet again, she'll recognize me," Catra admits softly. "That she'll look at me and just- just *know.* That she'll put the pieces together because even though I can't say my mortal name anymore, I can still fulfill my promise I made to her lifetimes ago."

And Catra thinks that it's sufficient enough of an answer. It gives too much information away but- in this state, Catra is *desperate* for Adora to realize that it's her.

She made her a promise when they were 15, to stand by her forever- to be her knight, to protect her even while they were fighting. Even if they weren't talking to each other.

She has spent 400 years fulfilling that promise, because in the end- that's all she is. Adora's Knight.

And that's all she wants to be, really. It brings her no greater joy than to be her Knight- to protect her.

But Adora still doesn't realize it. Still doesn't understand what she's saying.

It's infuriating- but really, she wasn't playing up how stupid Adora can be sometimes, earlier.

"..I see," Adora sighs heavily, like she's being weighed down by something invisible. "That's a good answer. I have to admit that I'm jealous of this beloved of yours."

Catra found that *highly* comical. She snorts, rolling her eye.

"Alright, Adora," She laughs. "Let's not get ahead of ourselves."

"But-"

"Shhh…" Catra closes her eye again, a smile tugging at her lips. "Quiet, now. I want to rest."

Adora doesn't protest any further.

—

Catra wakes up in a slightly older body, which means her power is slowly returning but will need to be… contained.

She opens her eyes- apparently, the skin she slipped into while asleep isn't blind in one eye -and adjusts to the harsh light before looking around the small shrine.

She finds Adora busying herself- sweeping the floor, tidying things that didn't need it. She looks… anxious- or, at least the way she's flitting about makes her look anxious. Catra never knew Adora to be an anxious cleaner- honestly, she didn't even know Adora could clean *anything.* She was weighed on hand and foot as the heir of the Fright Kingdom, so seeing her cleaning was… out of the ordinary, to Catra.

"Did hell freeze over or are you seriously cleaning right now?" Catra says, voice groggy and ragged from sleep. She makes an attempt at clearing her throat but it doesn't fix much of anything. Adora huffs out a laugh and drops the broom from her hand.

"Very funny," Adoar replies, completely deadpan. "I was just… you know, making myself busy while you were asleep."

"How long was I out for?"

"...Three days."

Catra's eyebrows shoot up into her hairline, not expecting *that* answer. "Impressive," Catra mumbles to herself, rubbing his eyes

with the back of her hand. “I didn’t expect that.”

The two stare at each other for a moment, both seemingly thinking over whatever they want to say. They both end up speaking at the same time-

“I think we should-”

“We should probably-”

And they’re both silent again, staring. “You can go first,” Adora says, smiling softly at her. “I don’t mind.”

Catra huffs, but sits up from her previous position so that she’s more eye level with Adora. “We should go and find Shadow Weaver,” She says. “I think if we brought more people into it, they’d just end up getting hurt. So… while I may be a liability, and I still don’t think it’s the best idea… we should go.”

“...I was thinking the same thing, actually,” Adora nods. “Do we have any ideas in regards to… you know, sniffing her out?”

“Her territory could be anywhere in the central plains, the west *or* the north,” Catra mumbles, thinking deeply as she stares ahead at the wall in front of her. “Those are all pretty vast territories, especially in the central plains and the North. At least towards the west, it’s big bodies of water that are easy to go over…”

“Okay well,” Adora stops herself, thinking, then- “Which territory is closest to both your and Double Trouble’s domains?”

“The central plains,” Catra responds immediately. “It’s between both of our territories. We can probably search through there and then head west, and if there’s nothing there then it means it’s…”

“North,” Adora finishes her sentence. “Which is going to be the hardest to trek through because it has the harshest temperatures.”

Catra nods solemnly. “Yeah,” She agrees, sighing heavily. “This is gonna be a *bitch* to travel through in this skin.”

“You can’t switch out into your true form?” Adora asks, curious. Catra grimaces.

“I mean, I can,” Catra answers. “I’m just staying like this to conserve energy.”

Sure, that’s one way to put it. Conserving energy is definitely.. what she’s doing.

“Honestly, I should probably use a smaller disguise…” Catra mumbles mainly to herself, closing her eyes and molding a new

disguise- smaller, that of a small child. It looks similar to how she did as a mortal child, but with differences- her eyes were both the same shade of blue, rather than one being yellow. Her hair wasn't matted, well kept and silky. Her hair in this form certainly wasn't as curly as it naturally is- she finds her curly hair to be a pain most of the time, but she likes it sometimes.

Adora squeals when Catra meets her eyes. "Oh my gods!" Adora exclaims, eyes wide and shining. "You're so- adorable! Can I carry you!?"

"Absolutely not, Adora." Catra says, deadpan. Adora squeals again and proceeds to completely disregard her, picking her up and holding her firmly on her hip. She smiles widely at Catra.

"Oh my gods, I can't believe this," Adora says, looking over Catra's face. "You look so adorable, gods, I can't take this!"

"Stop calling me adorable."

"Aww… why?! It's true!"

"It's absolutely *not."*

"You're no fun."

"...Let's just get going."

Adora kept squealing over her while she packed a few things for them for the road. Catra supposed it was a good idea that she was packing- they'd be gone for a while.

"Do you want to stop in Halfmoon before we start searching?" Catra asks, breaking Adora out of her concentration. "You can pick whatever weapon you want from the armory."

Adora stops in her tracks fully, now. She seems to pause and mull it over before her shoulders drop. "The offer is tempting, but I think I'll be alright with the Sword of Protection." Adora responds, turning her head over her shoulder to look at Catra. "Why? Do you want to go? I don't see how Melog won't be sufficient enough for this…"

Catra becomes sheepish at the mention of them. "Well, you see.." Catra laughs nervously, commanding Melog in her mind to come out from where they were hiding. Melog, in their cat form, crawls out from underneath a cabinet and reveals itself- and it's about the size of Catra. "...If I shrink, so does Melog."

Adora coos at the size of Melog, fully turning around now and bending to pet them on the head. "Oh my gods, aren't you the cutest?" She awes, scratching the cat behind their ears. Melog purrs, closing their eyes and pushing their head into her touch. "Look at you…"

“Melog, enough,” Catra huffs, glaring at them. “Stop dirtying her highness’s hands- and stop being so greedy!”

Melog keens and pushes its head further into Adora’s hand. Adora pouts, staring lovingly down at Melog. “Oh, they’re so cute, they could never dirty my hands!”

She gently picks up the cat, and cradles them in her arms. Catra scowls and averts her gaze, not daring to watch the terrible spectacle any longer. Melog purrs loudly in Adora’s hold- and Catra hates that Melog is an extension of herself in moments like these. If she could keep that wretched thing as a sword all of the time, she would- but even then, they’re sentient…

She is in a perpetual lose-lose situation no matter what. “Let’s just get going, your highness..”

“Let me just inform Eternia of where we’re going,” She says, scratching behind Melog’s ears absentmindedly. “Just in case, you know?”

Catra nods and watches as Adora raises two fingers to her temple, keeps them there for a moment, then lowers them. She smiles at Catra and nods, “Okay, it’s all done! Let’s get goi-”

Three sharp knocks on the door. Adora furrows her brows and turns, opens the door with one hand, the other still cradling Melog.

“We’re coming with you.” Glimmer steps into the shrine, arms crossed. Her eyes sweep the entire inside, before settling on Catra. “Who’s child is that, Adora?”

Adora looks at Catra. Catra glares at her. Adora grins at her and looks back towards Glimmer, “Mine.”

The most awkward silence of Catra’s afterlife follows, with Bow smiling politely (though, it’s definitely strained) and Glimmer blinking at Adora blankly.

“Adora, be serious.” Glimmer says, eyes narrowing. “Who is that?”

Adora deflates and pouts- but, well, the lie (or joke, Catra isn’t sure what that was supposed to be) wasn’t going to last. There is no way that Catra could even *pass* as Adora’s child- in a condensed form or not. It was ridiculous!

(Catra was embarrassed.)

“...It’s Catra.” Adora mumbles sadly. Glimmer’s eyes widen, and then she bursts out into the most boisterous laughter that Catra has ever heard. She narrows her eyes and crosses her arms, huffing.

“That’s- THAT’S Ghost Queen Crimson Night Striking Mercilessly!?” Glimmer exclaims in between laughs. “Why is she so small!? A child- she’s a child! Oh, this is amazing!”

“Hey glitter, you smell less godly today,” Catra says, monotone. “Did the Emperor take some of your godhood back?”

Glimmer quickly shuts up, glaring at her. Bow grimaces next to her, and Adora- ever the peacemaker, sometimes -tries to smile. But, of course, it is terribly strained.

Catra glares back, but gives in- not having the energy to fight Glimmer today.

“Whatever, fine,” She mumbles, looking away and hunching her shoulders. “They can come, I guess. Might as well invite the rest of Eternia, while we’re at it.”

Adora rolls her eyes and picks up Catra too, now holding both Catra *and* Melog in each of her arms. Catra’s eyes widen, squealing slightly at the abrupt move. Glimmer snorts.

“Amazing!” Adora exclaims happily, smiling at Catra as she holds her tighter. “Let's go!”

Catra may just evaporate into her wraith cats on this trip of theirs.

—

They search the central plains for a good while, with Catra sending out her cat clones to look as well- just to speed up searching. They tell Glimmer and Bow their next plan of action if they find nothing there in the central plains: They'll head west next, and then north if they find nothing.

The central plains proved to be a gigantic bust. True to their counterpart in the mortal world, It's just plain fields that quickly turn into dry deserts similar to that of the Crimson Waste. The central plains however, is a very vast territory. All of that to say: they find absolutely nothing of interest in the central plains. When Catra checked in with her cat clones, all they had found were ruins or old villages and towns that were obviously built by mortals.

So, they headed west.

Or, at least, they think they did. They've already determined that it's hard to tell which way is North and which is South while in a desert.

So, essentially they were wandering aimlessly.

"Did either of you bring a map?" Glimmer moans, slouching terribly and sweating profusely. "I can't take much more of this heat! Just let me teleport us!"

"No," Catra huffs, rolling her eyes. "There is no map for us to even *look* at. The kind of map we'd need for this doesn't even exist! And you can't teleport us- remember what happened the last time? This is an oddly similar situation…"

"Last time was a fluke!"

“Yeah, okay sure it was,” Catra mumbles. “Either way, I’m having a great time just walking around. Don’t you agree, your highness?”

Adora looks like she could blink and die at any second. She sighs heavily and readjusts Catra on her hip, “Yup, totally…”

“Yeah, well, that’s easy for you to say,” Glimmer grumbles, crossing her arms over her chest. “You’re able to use all your power and energy to be in a smaller form- one that can be carried!”

Catra realized very early on that if she whined and complained for a minute or two, Adora would take pity, pout at her with eyes full of stars, and pick her up. And then fuss over her, as if she was an actual child. Catra took advantage of this- because she was a normal person (a ghost, but whatever) with normal desires. And with the way things were going for her currently… she’d much rather succumb to the desire of being held up by Adora’s strong… muscled arms… then give in to her *other* one’s.

So she has been carried for a majority of the journey, while the three gods had to walk. Catra thinks that's the way it should be, anyways. Just as compensation for getting her fate stolen. She thinks it's a fair trade.

Catra rolls her eyes and clings just a bit tighter to Adora- might as well, right?

"Contrary to your beliefs, Shimmer, this is me *conserving* energy."

"Hey, guys, what's that in the distance?" Bow shields his eyes with one hand and points with the other. Catra narrows her own eyes as she looks in the direction that he points- but it just looks like a spec in the vast desert. She commands one of her cat clones to wander the vicinity of the figure, then closes both of her eyes to look through the eyes of her cat clone, instead.

What she sees makes her audibly groan.

It's a girl, maybe just a bit taller than her in this current form, with pink skin and even pinker hair. Her ears are pointed upwards, and her hair is pulled into two buns. It looks like the girl has wings, but that could also just be a part of the dress she was wearing.

Now- this itself was not… out of the ordinary, Catra supposes. She would think nothing of it- if she wasn't already very acquainted with this specific clone of Double Trouble's. Flutterina, as they call it.

"What's wrong?" Adora asks her softly, coaxing her into opening her eyes. Catra simply rolls them with a huff, "It's a person. I can't tell if it's a Ghost or just some kind of weird fairy breed. Maybe both?"

"Let's go towards them, then!" Adora smiles brightly, glancing towards Glimmer and Bow. "Maybe they could help?"

Catra wants to groan, but she holds it in. She truly does *not* want to deal with DT or any of their clones currently, but… well, Adora may be right. If a DT clone is here, maybe they could find their way again?

Glimmer and Bow exchange a glance, seemingly thinking of something similar. They both shrug in the end and agree. They begin walking in the direction of the person- and Catra is grateful to not have to talk to any of them, so she could instead connect to DT's communication array and… interrogate them a bit.

She repeats DT's communication array in her head thrice, then feels the tell-tale echoey chamber in her mind that lets her know she's successfully connected. She feels DT's presence almost immediately within the array.

"Hello, darling! I see you!"

"Why is your clone he– wait, hold on, you- you see me?"

There is a pause, then DT continues, *"Well, yes, that tends to happen when you have two working eyes, kitten."*

There is another pause, this time due to Catra silently counting to ten to calm herself down. The jab towards her lack of an eye in her true form was not lost on her.

"If you see us, does that mean Flutterina isn't a clone?"

"Precisely," DT confirms easily, laughing airily. *"I sensed movement towards the outer edge of my domain, so I naturally came in disguise to investigate the matter. What a surprise to see Her Highness the Crown Princess and the fearsome Crimson Knight!"*

"DT," Catra murmurs, fists clenching in Adora's robes. Adora shoots a worried glance towards her, faltering in whatever she was saying to Glimmer. Catra sends her a tight lipped smile in response. *"Sincerely, do you have a death wish?"*

"Kitten, I'm already dead," Their laughter only manages to intensify. The sound grates on Catra's ears, the way it rattles off against the walls of her head. *"Besides, I'm not scared of you.*

We're right by my domain, and you know to never pick a fight with anyone- god or ghost -in their own territory."

"Whatever." Catra huffs, knowing very well that their words are completely true. A god- or ghost -will always be the strongest in their domain, in their own territory. Not even the Eternian Emperor would dare to fight Catra in her domain of Halfmoon. *"So, will you help us or what?"*

A dramatic sigh.

"I suppose I can find it in the kindness of my cold, unbeating heart…"

"Oh, wow, I didn't know that you ever had a heart to begin with."

Silence.

"I could also, you know, not help, Kitten."

"And then your ashes will cease to exist."

"Don't act so high and mighty," DT purrs, smirking when the group 'bumps' into each other. Their eyes train on the ring around Adora's neck- the one Catra had left for her that first night in

Thaymor after they first met again. *"I know where yours are, too."*

Catra snarls and backs out of the communication array now that they are all face-to-face. DT is always unpleasant to talk to. That never changes, no matter how many times they speak…

"Hello!" DT exclaims, looking up at the group with child-like wonderment. They then sniff the air and put on a shocked act. "Are you gods?"

They all exchange a look, meanwhile Catra stares at them, no emotion in her eyes.

"Uh, yeah?" Adora answers hesitantly, but quickly recovers. "We're looking to head west! Do you happen to know if we're headed in the right direction?"

DT squeals excitedly, wings fluttering behind them to… well, Catra wasn't sure what the reason behind that was, actually. "Wow! I've never met *real* gods before!" DT says, eyes full of stars. The display is nauseating. "My name is Flutterina- can I journey with you all? It'd be my greatest honor to be able to travel alongside gods!"

"Uh, yeah… sure!" Adora agrees readily, and Catra just wants to punch her repeatedly in the head. But- well, she softens slightly when she sees the excited look on Adora's face, the way she

smiles and genuinely seems *happy* to have this… seemingly alive little girl follow them around. Catra's long dead heart skips a beat in her chest.

And so the journey through the central plains to the west began. It was absolutely grueling, in Catra's opinion- but, well, that could have also been from the fact that DT and Glimmer were *both* there.

"So, what are you gods doing out here?" 'Flutterina' asks, leading the group cheerfully. "Are you guys here on order of the Emperor?"

"Oh, ha.." Adora laughs nervously, bouncing Catra in her arms. "..No, this is like a… personal side mission."

"Oh, really?" 'Flutterina' purses her lips, looking over her shoulder at them. "So you aren't here to investigate the tremors in the earth?"

Catra's eyes widen, and she quickly enters DT's communication array.

"Tremors?"

"Yup." DT pops the 'p'.

"...So it's true?"

"Unfortunately so, kitten."

Catra sighs within the array. She could feel a headache coming…

"I thought it was just Eternia sucking the energy out of me…"

"Nope! Just Tong'lu opening." DT sighs now, shaking their head. *"Why do you think I took this skin on? If I were in my true form, and it opened, who knows what would happen…"*

"I don't think I can be around her highness when it opens."

Silence.

"It could be any day now, kitten." DT says- and they sound genuinely concerned. *"Why are you so afraid, anyways? This form you're in- you should be okay.."*

"Tong'lu intensifies desires," She murmurs, just now realizing how *bad* this could be. *"What happens if I let my guard down and go back into my true form while she's there?"*

DT seems to think over her words for a moment- and then the same realization seems to dawn on them, too. *"Oh. Yeah, okay, I see where you're coming from, kitten. I'll try to get us towards the west as fast as possible."*

"How can you ensure that?"

"We've entered my domain as of… five minutes ago. I can rearrange the landscape to bring us straight to the western edge."

"...Thank you, DT."

"Of course, kitten." They smirk, and suddenly any gratitude she felt towards them washed away. *"This won't come without a price, though."*

"I'm going to kill you."

"You can try, darling."

She leaves the array and huffs, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck and pouting.

“Look! We’re almost to the edge!” ‘Flutterina’ exclaims, pointing towards the rapidly coming horizon. “Just beyond that is the west, so you guys will be where you wanted!”

“Oh, wow,” Bow murmurs, looking forward. The desert abruptly comes to an end, leading to a flat grassland- but just beyond that seemed to be a dock and a large body of water. “..How are we going to get over that?”

“There are rumors that no boats can cross that ocean,” ‘Flutterina’ begins to explain, cheery as ever. “Only wood and vessels that have carried the deceased can cross.”

“...Uh, how sure are you of that?” Glimmer asks, grimacing. Flutterina shrugs, smiling, “It’s kind of just a hunch! Everyone who has tried, ended up sinking. So…”

“How would we even do that?” Glimmer groans, stepping over the edge of the desert and onto the grassland. “We don’t have a coffin.”

“Not that I’d ever help you two,” Catra speaks up now, turning to look over her shoulder and smile at Glimmer. “But say… Adora builds a coffin- the second I lay down on it, it becomes a vessel that has carried ‘the deceased’. So technically… it should be able to float over it.”

“And if you make another one, if you guys let me go with you-” ‘Fluterrina’ bounces on the balls of her feet excitedly. “I can share the coffin-boat with you two, and it’ll float!”

Horrified looks cross everyone’s faces except Catra. She, personally, thought it was very obvious that this skin of DT’s was that of a ghost, but she supposes to unsuspecting gods, it looks like an alive little girl…

“...Well, it looks like we have our plan, haha!” Adora exclaims awkwardly, trying to break the tension. “Let’s get to work cutting down… the trees? How do you even build a coffin?”

“I can help, your highness.” Catra says, tapping her shoulder gently. Adora seems to understand her unspoken question and places her down on the ground. Catra transforms into a teenage disguise- not exactly ideal with the current happenings, but it would have to do for now. “You guys go and gather wood. I’ll stay here and watch this kid.”

‘Flutterina’ pouts and crosses her arms. She goes to open her mouth, obviously to rebuke Catra’s words- but Adora smiles and looks towards a grumpy Glimmer and an apprehensive Bow. They both reluctantly follow after Adora to gather wood to make into two coffin boats.

“So..”

“Don’t talk.” Catra grumbles, walking around aimlessly, DT following after. “This situation is terrible.”

“You know those skeletal lizards that roam my domain?” DT asks suddenly, their real voice coming through the skin of Flutterina. Catra nods her head and looks down at them. “Yeah, so something similar *definitely* lurks in these waters, kitten. Skeletal fish that are easily provoked.”

“DT,” She sighs, rubbing at her temples with her index and middle fingers. “Are you really coming with us?”

“Of course, darling!” DT responds, flipping their imaginary hair over their shoulder. “I want to be there when you discover this new ghost territory… especially if it belongs to Shadow Weaver.”

“Why? So you can try to crawl into her bed?” Catra snarls, fists clenching. “If this leads to her, I will do whatever it takes to end her for good.”

“Will you send halfmoon after her?”

Catra scoffs and looks away from the horizon- there was nothing else she could see but water. She wonders if there really is anything on the other side.

“No, they’re incompetent,” She mumbles- but there was no malice to her words, just fondness. “I would never send any of them near her. This is my battle- this is Adora’s. It’s our battle.”

“How poetic, kitten,” DT comments with a heavy sigh. “The Princess and her loyal knight, facing their final battle together… The end is on the horizon for you. What happens after she finds out?”

Catra gulps and shuts her mouth. She hadn’t thought this far, in all honesty, but- she knows what will happen, when the day comes. She deflates, closes her eyes tightly.

“She won’t want me, anymore,” She whispers, voice cracking ever so slightly. “But that- that’s happened before. I’ll manage. She doesn’t have to want me, I… I’ll love her regardless, you know? That’s what unconditional love, isn’t it? Loving someone without the expectation of being loved in return.”

“You lack faith in your god.” DT furrows their brows, looking up at her with a confused look. “Which is odd for a girl who usually has a sort of blind faith when it comes to her.”

“It’s not that I lack faith,” She huffs, crossing her arms and looking up towards the sky to block the tears from falling. Her chest felt tight, her throat felt clogged- she imagines this is how it feels to drown. She wonders if water demons bear the weight of their death the way she does with hers, if they have to live out the rest of their afterlife feeling as though they’re being crushed underneath the weight of the unforgiving ocean. “It’s that… I’ve

read this story before, I know how it ends. No matter how many times you read your favorite book, the ending never changes."

"I suppose so," DT replies, glancing back towards Adora- who was walking towards them, carrying lugs of wood. "But I wouldn't be so sure, kitten. The ending always stays the same unless you rewrite it. Don't you remember your words to me in the kiln, all those decades ago?"

Catra looks down at them, mirroring their earlier expression of confusion. "I've said many things over the last 4 centuries, remind me?"

"Your fate is yours to choose," DT answers, eyes and voice slowly shifting back into the ones that belong to the skin. "No paths are bound. Always search for the third path. Darling, I have seen every moment of your life and you have seen every one of mine. You crawled your way out of hell, and you became what you are today. Sure, you got some baggage- don't we all, though? Who is to say you can't change your ending?"

Catra looks towards the horizon again, shaking her head. "This conversation is over, DT. I won't listen to you lecture me about *fates* and our *paths* and how I can reclaim what is mine."

"If you listen, maybe you'll be in a better position, kitten…"

"I got the wood we need!"

Catra whirls around on her heels, admiring the way Adora's muscles pull in her arms from holding up stacks of wood. She pulled the sleeves of her robes up to air out her strong arms…

Catra is a mess.

"Perfect, your highness," She smiles, though it's strained. "I'll put it all together and we'll be on our way."

—

"Okay, so," Catra looks over both coffin-boats that they built. She points to the smaller one, "Adora and I will go in the one, you three can go in the big one."

"Woah, hold on-" Glimmer shouts, crossing her arms. "How do we know you won't try something in that coffin?"

A silence washes over the group as Catra stares blankly at Glimmer. Glimmer seems to realize the implications of her words and averts her gaze. "Okay, whatever, fine. Let's just go."

"Great." Catra nods, motioning towards the coffin boat. "I'll go in first?"

"Yeah, that's fine." Adora smiles and nods her head in agreement. Catra sends a strained smile back and steps into the coffin. She would have to close the lid and seal it once Adora was in…

Adora peers over the side of the coffin at Catra with an unsure expression on her face. "Uh, Catra… do you think we made it… too small?"

Catra, in this teenage form, was comfortable with the amount of space she had when it came to how big the coffin was horizontally… but now, upon further thought, Adora would have to lay *on top* of her since they didn't build the boat with enough vertical space for her to lay down next to her…

Catra sighs and motions to herself, "Just lay down on top of me. I'll be fine."

Adora still didn't look that convinced, but she slowly- and carefully -layed herself down on top of Catra. She made sure to not… lay herself completely on her, the most that touched were their legs. Adora held herself up with her hands, her hair falling and creating a shield of sorts around her head. Catra suddenly wished that Adora still wore that… stupid ponytail of hers, instead of choosing her (new) normal half-up half-down hairstyle.

Catra gulps and closes the coffin lid with one hand, then seals it to make sure no water can enter it should they sink.

“Catra, what’s your communication array password?” Adora asks, eyes darting around the small confined space. Catra feels her face heat up in embarrassment when she remembers just what she set it as. “I’ll make a communication array for all of us to communicate in, since they’re in a separate coffin.”

Catra, originally, made her communication password deeply unpleasant- mainly because she never wanted anyone to contact her. But now, in the face of Adora… she can’t find it in herself to say it. It’s too… crass. Coming out of Adora’s mouth, it would sound like some kind of… sacrilegious phrase.

In a way, it sort of is..

“Ha, your highness…” Catra laughs nervously, feeling bashful suddenly. “My communication password is truly… not necessary…”

Adora pouts, “I think it is… what if I need to contact you in the future when you aren’t around? Then what do I do?”

Catra is at a loss for words- Adora is anticipating seeking her out in the future? Does this extend past their mission together regarding Shadow Weaver?

“Her Highness is always welcome in Halfmoon.”

Adora starts doing *fucking puppy-dog eyes at her.* "Please~ It's not that bad, I promise! I won't make fun of you!"

Catra closes her eyes tightly, then she sighs in resignation. "Your highness, come closer, I'll whisper it in your ear."

…She might as well have some fun with it, if she's going to tell her.

Adora moves to balance from her hands to her elbows, bringing her and Catra's faces just a hair away from each other. She tilts her head so that her ear is right by Catra's mouth.

She whispers her array password into Adora's ear- and her eyes go wide. She adjusts to be pushing herself up on her hands again, her face the reddest Catra has ever seen it be. Catra smirks, satisfied with the reaction.

"W-What the hell prompted you to make *that* your password!?"

"I didn't want anyone to talk to me," She responds easily. "So, if my password is unpleasant… then, well, no one will try."

Adora turns away, most likely unable to look Catra in the eyes. "..Okay, I'll create the array now with all of us.."

A minute later, she is unfortunately in an array with Glimmer, Bow and Adora.

"Did you guys get in your boat yet?" Adora asks, voice ringing through Catra's head pleasantly.

"Not yet, your highness." Bow answers Adora with a sigh. *"Do you need something?"*

"Can you push ours into the water?"

Glimmer groans, *"Can't you have Crimson Knight do that? I'm sure she has some kind of magic to be able to push it in…"*

"Just do it, Sparkles." Catra interjects loudly, rolling her eyes. *"We can be the test to see if the coffin floats or not."*

That seems to convince Glimmer enough. They feel the coffin slowly be pushed, and then eventually- they feel the slow rocking of the ocean.

"Well," Adora says out loud, smiling down at Catra. "Looks like it floats!"

“For now,” Catra murmurs, staring past Adora and at the coffin lid. “This is only shallow waters. The real test is if we get further out and don’t immediately sink to the bottom…”

Adora grimaces. “..I think it’ll be okay.”

“We can only hope.”

. . .

The boat did end up floating- however, the farther out they got, the choppier the waves. Adora ended up having to give up holding herself above Catra, pressing her body against Catra’s. Every now and then, she would try again- but her head would bump against the lid.

“...Catra, shouldn’t we switch so I’m on the bottom and you on top?” Adora asks after a while, face slowly growing more and more red. Catra furrows her brows.

“Top and bottom are the same, are they not?”

Adora gulps, briefly meeting Catra’s eyes and then darting away. “This journey… under the assumption that there really is something that we’ll land on, will take at least a day… and the body you’re in currently, it’s of a teenager, right?”

Catra nods, and Adora laughs nervously.

"...So, well.. I'm a martial god, I'm quite heavy… and if your body is of a 16, 17 year old currently… won't I be too heavy for you-"

Catra, unwilling to be on top of Adora (she finds amusement in this thought, but then stops her train of thought when she realizes how improper it is), transforms into her true form.

In her teenage form, she had enough room in the coffin to not have to bend her legs- but in her true form, which gave her a few extra inches of height, she had to bend her legs to be able to fit. It just so happened that her legs bent right in between Adora's- causing her to widen her eyes.

"C-Catra, you can't just… become bigger!"

She laughs, cause really- it was amusing to her, it was amusing how flustered Adora became (whether it be from her going into her true form or from her 'accidentally' pushing her between Adora's).

But now, she was in her true form- which had heightened senses. She could hear movement from outside the coffin, followed by the coffin boat rocking. Catra narrows her eyes and places her hand on the wall of the coffin to steady herself.

“Don’t move.” She urges Adora, who had just placed *her* leg between Catra’s- most likely to flip their positions. Adora furrows her brows- but quickly mirrors Catra’s position and holds her hand on the coffin’s wall.

“What’s happening?” She asks, confused. Her eyes darted around the coffin, but it provided no help.

A roaring sound comes from outside the coffin, followed by the two of them forcibly switching positions. It was as if the coffin boat had been rolled around…

Catra grunts at the sudden movement, her entire body pressing against Adora’s. She exhales out of her nose despite the fact that she doesn’t have to breathe, and- mostly for Adora’s sake, she’s content to stay pushed against her like that -kneels as best as she can to provide room between her and Adora. She doesn’t mind the way her head bumps against the lid. With one hand steadying herself on the wall and her other by Adora’s head, she murmurs, “Something’s got its eye on the coffin.”

Almost as soon as she said that, a weightless feeling encapsulated the two of them- only to be crashed down into an upright position. The coffin, having seemingly landed on water, smashed down- forcing Adora on the bottom once again, flipping the coffin upside down. Catra quickly realized that whatever this was- most likely those skeletal fishes that DT warned her of earlier -had no intention of letting up. She quickly abandoned holding the wall in favor of gripping Adora’s waist, holding her tightly to her body with both of her arms.

“Hold on tight to me, your highness!”

Adora looked… conflicted, but tried her best either way, holding on to Catra with one hand while the other takes Catra’s place on the coffin wall. “What happens if the coffin breaks!?”

“You’ll be safe, you won’t sink cause I’m here.” Catra assures her.

The coffin continues to be manhandled, as if a toddler had taken the coffin boat as its toy and was shaking it around. It pushed the two up against each other, shifting them into various positions, banging into various parts of each other all the while. It was safe to say that they had… thoroughly rubbed up against each other- and, because of this, Catra realized just how… hard Adora is. She’s just… straight muscle, with no softness. Catra supposes that’s what happens when you’re a martial god…

Catra ended up on top of Adora again, body pressing down heavily on her, most definitely suffocating her. Her knee was in between Adora's legs- and she tries to shift up slightly to be in a more comfortable position… until her knee hits something wet.

Catra’s brain short circuits for a moment- because *seriously?* Right now? She looks down at Adora, who was heaving and seemingly oblivious to the reaction her body has seemed to have amidst the craziness of being jostled around.

“Is it over…?”

Adora gulps, then meets Catra's shocked gaze once she realizes she hasn't responded. Adora stares at her for a moment, confused- and then, the realization must dawn on her, because her face twists up in horror and her legs clamp shut around Catra's. Catra can't help the smirk that finds its way on her face at the reaction (though, she's still how Adora could react in such a way while in a *coffin.)*

Adora closing her legs ended up causing her knee to brush against Catra- who jolts, grunts, and then exclaims, "Don't move!"

Adora flattens her legs again, trying her hardest to keep her legs closed so that Catra doesn't move- all while avoiding her gaze.

Catra goes to speak- until their tormentor from the ocean continues to bang into the coffin. Except now- things were a lot… awkwarder. The two of them continued to knock into each other, but at the faintest even nudge against Adora in the wrong way, she would *whine.* It got to the point that she shut her eyes as tight as possible so she didn't have to look at Catra.

(And Catra wouldn't admit it, but she wasn't in any better condition than Adora, she just knew how to hide it.)

Unfortunately, however, their coffin boat could only take so many beatings.

The coffin breaks open, plunging the two of them into the water. Catra takes initiative- because she's currently more coherent than poor Adora -and grabs onto her, holding her close to her chest (despite Adora being taller) and creates a small pocket of air around them.

They won't sink as long as the bubble is around them- but Catra also knows that she won't be able to keep it up for long. In her current condition, her energy was rapidly decreasing by doing the absolute bare minimum.

Adora belatedly wraps her arms around Catra and *whimpers.* Catra wishes she could drown.

"Don't worry, your highness," She says, cradling Adora's head. "We'll be okay…"

If Catra can convince herself they'll be fine, then- they should be fine!

Except they aren't fine, because her energy is depleting fast- and before she knows it, the bubble pops and they're sinking. Catra simply sighs, closing her eye so that the ocean water won't sting her eyes, and resigns her fate to sinking.

Adora- well, she goes down fighting.

Catra falls unconscious shortly after.

—

Catra wakes up to the sun beating down on her body- but she doesn't dare open her eyes. She feels wet all over, and she thinks she feels sand between her toes and claws…

So, they managed to wash up on a beach. She distantly wonders what happened to Glimmer, Bow and DT…

And then she hears movement to her left, then her body is being shaken slightly.

"Catra?" Adora whispers, hands on her shoulders. Catra decides she wants to play a little joke on Adora, and pretends to still be asleep…

"Catra…?" Adora says again, raising her voice. When Catra doesn't respond, she pokes her cheek lightly. Catra still doesn't budge. She hears Adora sigh heavily, but nothing more for a minute or so…

And then she hears a clapping sound- as if Adora clapped her hands together -and Adora mumbling, "Please, forgive me…"

Then, Catra's eyes snap open- because Adora's *kissing her.* Adora's eyes are closed, and she pulls back slightly- and if she just *opened her eyes* she would realize Catra is *awake.* But no, life is not fond of Catra, because Adora's hand rests on the side of her face, thumb just underneath her mouth, and pulls her mouth slightly open. Adora descends again, their open lips making contact-

And that's when Catra realizes… Adora isn't *kissing her,* she's trying to *give her CPR!*

But it's terrible CPR, because it's kind of like one-sided making out- and *Catra doesn't even need CPR, she's already dead!*

Adora's hands cradle her face as she pulls back again- and *now* her eyes flutter open. She freezes in place, staring down at Catra- and the look of terror on Adora's face is most likely a mirror of her own. They're in a stalemate of sorts, until Adora springs back, hands pressed together as if to pray, and bows several times towards Catra.

"I'm sorry!" She exclaims, standing up abruptly. "It's not what it looks like- I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry-"

Adora *runs away.* She just… bolts, on a random island seemingly in the middle of nowhere, yelling apologies to Catra.

"Your highness, please wait–!"

Catra stands up as well, trying to follow after Adora- but she's managed to lose her. She has no choice but to follow her footprints in the sand and hope to find her in the forest.

Catra sighs, stepping into the forest and grimacing at the feeling of sand stuck in her claws. She feels uncomfortably wet, and it's particularly annoying on her face. She unties her eyepatch and snuffs it in pockets in her sleeves, hoping to air out both the eyepatch and the wound on her eye. Though the wound has been closed and healed, it still wasn't any good to let it sit within the eyepatch for too long- especially after it's been wet. She learned the hard way that it'll manage to get infected, and then it'll have this strong, pungent odor…

So, no one was around which meant no one would have to see the hideous scar concealed by her eyepatch.

"Your highness!" Catra yells, looking around the forest. "Adora?!"

Nothing. How far could she have traveled into this forest?

She bends down and crouches, lifting her arm out and watching as her wraith cats hop out of her vambraces and sit down in front of her. She pets each of them on the head, "Go and look through the forest for Adora."

They follow her commands immediately, each running into different directions. She stands back up and pulls Melog out of their sheath and allows them to transform into their cat form.

Seeing as Catra was in her true form, Melog was about up to her waist. Seeing them like this, it was almost like they were a tiger… Catra pouts remembering just how small Melog used to be when she first met them…

Melog meows and rubs their head against her side happily. She grimaces, but begrudgingly pets their head as well, murmuring, "Yeah, yeah, whatever. I know, you missed me. Let's just go find Adora, alright?"

. . .

She is not sure how long the two of them looked for, until Adora ran *right* into them in the middle of the forest. The two stared at each other- and then Catra realized her eyepatch was still off, and she quickly covered her marred eye socket with her hand, yelling, "Don't look- don't look, your highness!"

Adora quickly turns around and spouts *more* apologies. Meanwhile, Melog hides behind Catra's legs shamefully, mewling loudly. She wants *so* badly to just transform them back into their sword form so that it wouldn't reflect this strongly on how she feels.

She quickly pulls her eyepatch out of her sleeve and hastily ties it on, clearing her throat and crossing her arms over her chest. "You… you can turn around again, your highness."

Adora hesitantly turns around, and she… doesn't meet Catra's eye. Her face was slightly red- from the heat of the island or from everything that happened earlier, Catra isn't sure.

Catra pouts, and Melog comes out from behind her legs. Melog walks towards Adora and nuzzles into her side, purring happily. Catra grimaces and rolls her eyes at Melog. "Hey, Adora." Catra steps forward, towards Adora- and Adora doesn't actually move away when she does.

Adora looks down at her, an unreadable expression in her eyes. Catra forces herself to quirk her lips upwards slightly into a small, but gentle, smile. "Don't run off like that again, please?"

Adora huffs a laugh and rolls her eyes, "What, are you my bodyguard? My knight?"

Catra shrugs, sweeps her robes out and kneels before Adora. She rests her arm across her knee and looks up at Adora with a smile- and distantly, she thinks, *wow, I never thought I'd be doing this again.*

Adora looks down at her in slowly dawning horror, urging her to stand up. "No, no- Catra, please no, I haven't had a knight in centuries…"

“So?” She replies, eyebrow raising. “You can appoint another one, can’t you?”

Adora looks at her with a complicated expression, but shakes her head no in the end. “No, I can’t… that would be disrespectful to the memory of…”

Adora looks away, but Catra knows who she was talking about.

C’yra.

And right there- that’s when Catra realizes she will never live up to C’yra. Adora… she loves *C’yra,* and even if Catra is her… she isn’t *really* her anymore, right? Even if Adora knew who she was, she… she would be disappointed to know C’yra turned into what she is today.

Adora loves C’yra, and she- she isn’t her anymore. Adora could never love her. She is currently *losing* to *herself.* It’s pathetic, yet she feels utterly miserable at the realization.

She sighs and stands up, dusting off her robes and welcoming a dejected Melog, scratching behind their ears as they whine. “Alright, I understand,” Catra nods, sending Adora a tight lipped smile. “Where to, your highness?”

Adora's face falls at the use of her title again, but quickly fixes it. "I found Glimmer and Bow earlier- they said they managed to lose Flutterina…" She tells her gently, grabbing her hand and pulling her towards where she found the two. Catra's heart feels cold. "We should just find them and keep going further into the island.."

"Good idea, your highness."

. . .

They end up in a small, dilapidated village full of ghosts.

"What is this place?" Bow asks absentmindedly, looking around. Glimmer shrugs next to him, swaying a bit and then leaning against him, "No idea but- there's a horde of ghosts over there."

Catra looks over towards the group of ghosts- they seemed to be traveling somewhere. "Let's follow them."

Everyone agrees, and they make their way over into the group of ghosts. They all disguise themselves to fit in more, and to not draw suspicion.

They walk in a general, tense silence. For once, it was because of Catra and Adora, rather than a quarrel between Catra and Glimmer.

She felt odd, following her realization. It was like she said to DT earlier- if she knows how it's going to end, why hope for anything

else? Adora will never choose her, she learned this a long time ago. It's just… it hurts her to know that Adora is only choosing her now, centuries after the fact- and even then, it doesn't benefit Catra. Adora is choosing *C'yra,* not *Catra.* So in a way, Adora was still choosing someone else over her…

But this time around, she didn't go into this expecting Adora to pick her. She simply wanted to be by her side, to serve her- cause that was enough to her.

It hurt, slightly, to be with her but not in the way she wanted. It hurt more to mean nothing to her.

So, in the end… Catra is fine just being Adora's friend.

Catra isn't sure how long they've walked when they walk through a large set of gates, leading into a dark, hazy, old looking city. Catra scrunched her face up in disgust, looking around the old buildings bustling with ghosts. What is this place? How come she never knew about it?

She looks ahead of her again- and horror slowly dawns on her. These… these people, they look like…

"Excuse me," Glimmer stops one of the citizens. The ghost, who looks more like a robot, stops and smiles… robotically. "What is this place?

The ghost's smile widens at the question. "Miss, this is the Sanctum- the capital city of NeoPrime!" The ghost exclaims proudly, green eyes devoid of all emotion. Catra… she… she can't…

Terror courses through her veins, and she can feel the phantom palpitations of her heart that no longer beats.

"NeoPrime…?" Bow repeats, glancing questioningly at Adora- who shrugs, also confused.

"Yes, sir!" The ghost nods excitedly, clapping their hands together. "The Kingdom of NeoPrime is run by Brother Horde Prime!"

Catra faints.

End Notes

What a wild ass ride, right? This was really fun to write after I convinced myself to keep writing it lol. A lot happened since the last fic installment- but one Era's tour (best night of my entire life, I can die happy after seeing 'tis the damn season and midnight rain live), and a few family emergencies later, this fic has been born. Adora this whole chapter is just one big mess of "IT'S NOT WHAT IT SEEMS IT'S NOT WHAT IT SEEMS OH MY GODS" and I think she deserves it.

anyways, thank you guys for sticking around and reading! I've recently moved to tumblr so this is me begging you all to please come and follow me there to listen to me scream about spop and a myriad of other things... I was also thinking about maybe making a discord server, so everyone can stay up to date on fic updates and the like? just a thought, not sure if anyone else is interested in that. Anyways, I hope everyone enjoyed this, it was so fun to write. Please don't forget to leave comments and kudos' as it motivates me to write faster so I can get more out for you guys! Thank you again, and I'll see you in the next one <333

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!